

Derbyshire Shared Care Pathology Guideline

Assessment of Sweating Prior to Suspected Lymphoma Referral

Guidance for Primary Care (aligned with NICE NG12)
From: Lymphoma Service

Purpose

Sweating, including night sweats, is a recognised symptom of lymphoma but is common and usually non-malignant when occurring in isolation. This guidance supports appropriate initial assessment in primary care, helps identify alternative causes, and clarifies when urgent referral is indicated.

Key Messages (Quick Reference)

- Sweating alone is rarely due to lymphoma.
- Lymphoma-related “B symptoms” are typically drenching, persistent, and progressive, and usually occur with other red flags.
- Normal examination and baseline blood tests make lymphoma unlikely.
- Urgent referral is appropriate when sweating is part of a wider concerning clinical picture.

NICE NG12 Context

NICE NG12 recommends urgent referral for suspected haematological malignancy when there are persistent, unexplained systemic symptoms in combination with other concerning features (e.g. lymphadenopathy, splenomegaly, cytopenias). Isolated sweating without additional red flags does not usually meet NG12 criteria.

When Sweating Is Unlikely to Represent Lymphoma

Lymphoma is unlikely when sweating is:

- The only symptom
- Long-standing (>6 months) without progression
- Mild or intermittent (not drenching)
- Associated with:
 - Normal lymph node examination
 - No splenomegaly
 - Stable weight
 - Normal baseline blood tests

True lymphoma-related sweats are typically drenching night sweats requiring a change of clothing or bedding, and are usually accompanied by other features.

Initial Assessment in Primary Care

History

Please document:

- Nature of sweating: night/day, drenching vs mild, frequency, duration
- Associated symptoms:
 - Weight loss (>10% in 6 months)
 - Persistent fevers
 - Fatigue
 - Pruritus
- Menopausal status
- Alcohol intake
- Medication history
- Anxiety or panic symptoms
- Recent infection, travel, or TB exposure

Examination

- Full lymph node examination (cervical, axillary, inguinal)
- Hepatosplenomegaly
- Thyroid status
- Signs of infection or inflammatory disease

Baseline Investigations to Consider

- FBC
- ESR
- U&E, LFTs, calcium
- LDH (normal result by no means excludes lymphoma but if significantly elevated with no other cause is suggestive of high grade lymphoma)
- TFTs
- HbA1c (or glucose)

Consider if clinically indicated:

- 9 am Testosterone (men)
- FSH (women if menopausal status unclear)
- HIV (if risk factors)

Normal results substantially reduce the likelihood of lymphoma.

Common Non-Malignant Causes of Sweating

Endocrine

- Menopause / perimenopause
- Hyperthyroidism
- Hypoglycaemia / diabetes
- Low testosterone in men

Infection

- Tuberculosis
- Endocarditis
- HIV
- Occult abscess
- Chronic sinus or dental infection

Medications

Common causes include:

- SSRIs / SNRIs
- Tricyclic antidepressants
- Opioids
- Metformin
- Corticosteroids
- Antipyretics
- Alcohol (including withdrawal)
- Most 'recreational' drugs

Autonomic / Functional

- Anxiety disorders
- Panic attacks
- Idiopathic hyperhidrosis
- Obstructive sleep apnoea

Inflammatory / Autoimmune

- Rheumatological disease

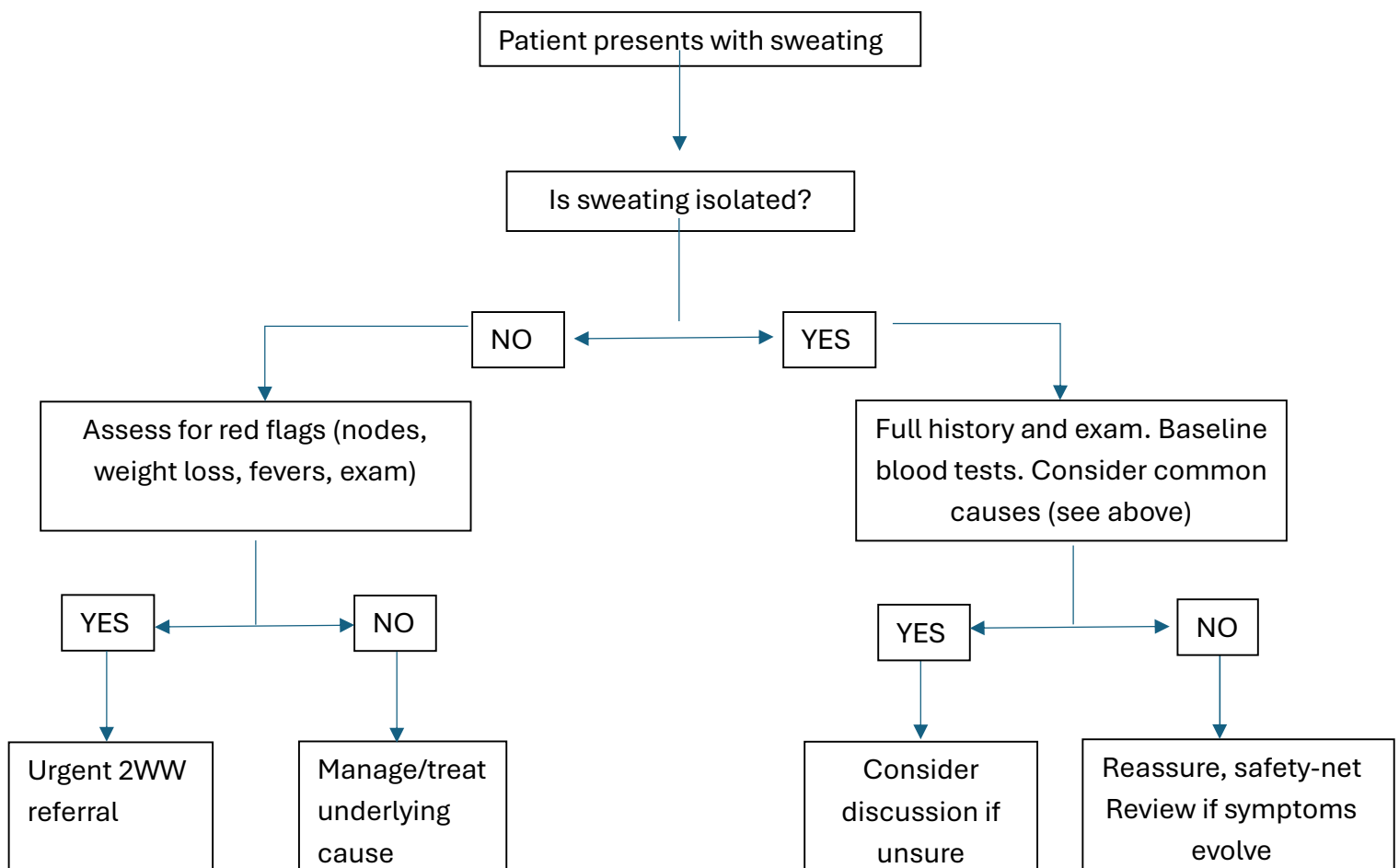
- Vasculitis
- Sarcoidosis

When to Refer Urgently to Haematology (2WW)

Please refer if sweating is accompanied by any of the following:

- Persistent, unexplained lymphadenopathy (>2 cm, firm, non-tender)
- Splenomegaly
- Unexplained cytopenias
- Elevated LDH (>2x normal) without alternative explanation
- without alternative explanation
- Significant unintentional weight loss
- Persistent fevers
- Rapid symptom progression
- Imaging suggestive of lymphoproliferative disease

Suggested Clinical Flowchart



Safety Netting

Patients should be advised to re-present if they develop:

- New or enlarging lymph nodes
- Weight Loss
- Persistent Fevers
- Worsening or drenching night sweats

Advice

We are always happy to discuss individual cases where there is diagnostic uncertainty

Further Guidance

Nice CKS guidance on Hyperhidrosis (Sept 2023)

[Hyperhidrosis | Health topics A to Z | CKS | NICE](#)

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